

The Reason I Jump // *Dramaturgy Pack*

Concept

The Reason I Jump is a site-specific immersive performance conceived by Graham Eatough constructed around the autobiography written by Naoki Higashida as well as the lived experiences of its performers. After acquiring the rights to the book, the National Theatre of Scotland commissioned Eatough to conceptualise a production around 2015. Eatough initially imagined a curatorial production in gallery spaces that experientially presented and narrativised different perspectives on autism for the audience, which they would travel through like the chapters of a book. From these early stages he was already keen to represent multiple individual experiences of autism in an immersive journey, and this has remained key to the dramaturgy throughout.

> That kind of dramaturgical approach was there from the start, as was the desire to work with people who have autism actually in making the project. Rather than it just being Naoki Higashida's ideas and point of view and experiences that are expressed in the book, we wanted a range of experiences and ideas presented in the show, of which Naoki's would be one.[1]

They identified a group of autistic participants and went through several workshops. The first paired participants with professional artists to develop a theme from the book in line with their own experiences in order to approach a space, a room. From this, and through Eatough's previous work on site-specific outdoor art collaborations, the dramaturgical journey shifted outside as Andre Dekker came on board and introduced his architectural approach. The move outside was particularly significant in playing into, and playing up, Naoki's ideas about nature in the book:

> a massive part of the book is Naoki's idea that he, and he assumes other autistic people, has this very special connection with nature and with outdoor spaces and with a feeling of connection, and belonging, in a natural environment. So that resonated really importantly with the shift outside and suddenly gave us a really clear outlet for that part of the book, a very direct way of expressing those ideas and a kind of foregrounding of this relationship with nature. Especially with the site, the particular site, that we identified.[1]



The site, The Children's wood and North Kelvin Meadow, was selected for its mix of urban usage, re-wilding, and community as the epitome of Naoki's ideals of people's relationship with nature. The performance is designed around the specifications of the site, and fits into a site-specific theatre tradition while it also aspires to be site-generic in its flexibility on tour.



> Because it is in a way site-specific, we have made it with North Kelvin Meadow in mind, and it will be specifically constructed to the contours and planting of that site. The fences will go around and through the trees that exist on that site, and we're making use of the wooded areas of the site in one way in terms of the storytelling And the more open ground areas, we're using them in another way in terms of the storytelling; we're incorporating different aspects of that site into the story, like the treehouse or beehive, or things that exist there already. And yet the ambition is that then this show will be transplanted somewhere else and have a similar process of specific adaptation, if you like, to whatever site ends up in. So I guess it could also be a site-specific show that tours.[1]

The labyrinth was installed permanently on the site in collaboration with Nick Fuller and the coordinators of the Children's Wood and North Kelvin Meadow. Collectively built and ceremonially opened, it will remain as a legacy of the performance and a meditative experience. In contrast, the maze has been designed for flexibility and transport, by Andre Dekker and Geert van de Camp of Observatorium. There is a crucial difference between a maze and a labyrinth that is essential to the dramaturgy of the opposing spaces set in contrast and conversation with each other.

> If the maze is an intellectual puzzle where you're always faced with choice and have to work it out, work out your route, using a certain bit of your brain, your rational, puzzling mind. The labyrinth is this unicursal experience, there's only one route, one way in and one way out, the same path that you can therefore give yourself up to. The idea being that that then opens up a different part of your psychology, of your thinking; it creates a different kind of mental space that you enter into as you walk the labyrinth. And of course there's thousands of years of spiritual practice that have grown up around this idea. That was just completely compelling for me when I found that out. Dramaturgically it's just really interesting. So you have these two very different kinds of stories, experiential stories, if you like, journeys expressed through these different physical structures. But the other compelling thing for me in terms of this show, was this idea of the way the brain works, the way the mind works, and of course that's what the book's about is the different ways in which different people's minds work.[1]



[1] **For the full interview with director Graham Eatough see Appendix A**

Adaptation

Developing a performance from Keiko Yoshida and David Mitchell's translation of Higashida's autobiography engages in a process of adaptation beyond that initial layer of translation. Graham Eatough brought in playwright and dramaturg Clare Duffy to adapt the text, which covers 58 questions posed to Higashida, largely by neurotypical people, about his experiences with autism, as well as several allegorical fables and short stories. Ranging from queries on behaviour to perspective and faith, the text presented a challenge for adaptation to a theatrical format that would, necessarily, step beyond conventional narrative modes. Duffy chose to delve into the text through an in-depth dramaturgical analysis of both structure and diction, aiming to unpack its core theme, its central shaft of light.


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> There was a kind of structural analysis and there was also a diction analysis – a kind of what's happening between the lines. So there's a document with different words that are highlighted. I was quite interested, how many times he uses the word 'please', how many times he talks about humanity.
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> Through the between the lines analysis it felt to me that there was quite a clear argument that Naoki was making, or that I was pulling out as a reader, that was saying something along the lines of 'I'm autistic, and I used to think why have I been born, now if you gave me a pill for it I wouldn't take it, the most important thing to me is nature, it's totally joyful, actually if there was a reason for being autistic I think we could help everybody because of our understanding of the value of nature'.[2]

This core argument is mirrored in the performance, and shaped the conversations Duffy and Eatough had with the four performers with autism who share their own experiences in the production. These interviews touched on similar topics through the structures Duffy brought in from her extensive research and preparation, though they were also filled with coincidental overlaps that complemented the cohesion of the monologues they resulted in.

> I did refer to my notes a bit but basically we had the conversations, Graham led a lot of the conversation and I kind of jumped in if I felt like I wanted to get something in particular. And then when I put it together I was really amazed at how brilliantly it all fit. So it felt like it was a little bit of magic, really.[2]


© Andre Dekker

These interviews were curated and incorporated in the script, weaving in excerpts from Higashida's book as well. During the first rehearsal week each cast member had a further conversation, reviewing their scripted monologues for accuracy and their comfort in sharing their experiences. They will all be performed in dedicated spaces

within the maze, which the audience can encounter as they navigate their way towards the central labyrinth. This maze and labyrinth design forms a pivotal part of the dramaturgy, both in its shaping of the garden space and in the experiences it offers.

> Where I see the labyrinth as an opportunity for you as a participant to have your own experience, nobody can access what it is that you're experiencing in the moment because it's silent and it's unique to your body and your time doing it, but everybody does the same walk together. So it's both completely different and the same at the same time, and it gives everybody access to the present time and space, which is experienced differently because we all have our different consciousness. The challenge of adapting the book is to create the context for that experience of the labyrinth to be meaningful as a way of giving the audience access to their thoughts, to their own experience of the world and autism, I think.
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> The other thing that the labyrinth does is that it brings you back to the earth because it's of a present time and space, so you create quite a gentle maze, a gentle puzzle, which is like creating the stage in which you can share some of the book, some of the actual text, but then also gives this idea that Naoki isn't autism. He's one boy with autism. [2]

Alongside the labyrinth, the dramaturgy of the maze was influenced by and interwoven with the subject of autism; responding to some of the things autistic people find difficult about traditional theatrical approaches through the openness of the space and experience of it. The subtle frustrations of the maze, in dead ends and the way it structures decisions of direction and movement, connect to some of the frustrations people with autism feel.

The adaptation of a text to more than just a performance but to a space, integrating a literary mode of adaptation with verbatim theatre, shapes a multi-facetted production reflecting more than the words or experiences of Naoki alone but rather offering an immersive insight into the diversity of the human mind and experience.

> The audience can go through all of it, as a theatre performance or in a minimalist way of just sensing the space, the labyrinth. It can open plurality of potential experience, and that is a conceptual, dramaturgical choice to make in terms of the adaptation of the book.



[2] **For the full interview with dramaturg Clare Duffy see Appendix B**

Design

As a site-specific production, the show is designed specifically for The Children's Wood and North Kelvin Meadow as a maze of accordion-like folding fences by Andre Dekker and Geert van de Camp of Observatorium, welcoming the audience to immerse themselves in the world of Naoki's garden. Building on a rich history of garden art, and engaging with the adaptation of a Japanese text to a Glaswegian context, the designers worked in consultation with community coordinators of The Children's Wood and North Kelvin Meadow to shape a reimagining of the space in its entirety.

> The Japanese aesthetics of making enclosed gardens is in two ways similar to our approach. First of all, we really like creating spaces for retreat or silence in open space, just to have a moment to observe the world around you, to look back, so to speak. So it's a moment of reflection on your everyday spaces, which is inherent in our public art. And the other thing is that their architecture is actually a profound way of stacking, not gluing, leaving each element intact to create a whole. So you would, for instance, also always see the beams cross in a terrace.



The crossing beams of the fences that shape the space into a maze echo the component-composite styles that are visible in much of Observatorium's work, while also cultivating a natural aesthetic in the choice of materials. Blending into a natural space in Glasgow's West End with a history of cultivation, re-wilding, and reclamation, the fences also define individual spaces for each performer, contributing to their narratives and reflecting their experiences of autism.

> The interior design of the huts is inspired by the stories of the actors. We thought it would be good to tell their story using a few objects, an interior, that explains how their lives are. And they came up with these ideas themselves. It just comes from their preferences: someone really adoring caterpillars, someone very much intrigued by fire, another who jumps around in his life, and the lady who has a brown belt in judo. So it's in the story and we manifest it in their spaces, and it supports the actors' performance. Otherwise you're a very lonely person, I'd say, as an actor.

The actors occupy spaces within the maze and labyrinth, concepts around which the production is dramaturgically centred. The audience choose their own route through a maze encountering performers before reaching the meditative, unicursal labyrinth at its heart. Through its folding fence design, the production encourages the audience to shape their own experience of the spaces, concepts, and stories that they are presented with.

> We started thinking about how to do kilometres of fencing, because it's quite a large space. So we remembered folding fences around roadworks, and this led us to the idea of the folding fence at varying heights. You pick it up, it's very light. The good thing is it's very transparent, but still, you know, it prevents you from going left or right. And due to this transparency you will see the other fences as well, so I expect it will create a sort of a hazy, tall grass atmosphere at different heights. You won't see the boundaries, an end.
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> It's actually a work of imagination, you know, in the sense that you can imagine all kinds of things within it. It's a very open design, for instance, the fences when very stretched are so open that you can step through them. So, will you do it or not? Will you break the rule or not? There is a playfulness about it

Part of that playfulness and flexibility is what allows the production to be transferrable to other sites if it goes on tour. In this way it becomes site-generic, remaining responsive to the space it occupies but adaptable to the precise contours and stories that different spaces carry. Tapping into varied traditions of using boundaries to redefine spaces as special, sacred, contributes to the approach taken with this design.



> Well, you could say, space defines my actions, my thinking; I am defined by space.
> It's a design for an open space that we can partition with flexible 'hedges', it could also be in a square. The only *voorwaarde,* the only condition, is a large open space.
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> It's as non-manipulative as possible. It's not nice to be manipulated by light, and sound, and not knowing what is real and what is fake. This meadow is very, very real. It's Glasgow, it's wild, it's a park. This is a theatre design that creates corners where you can retreat, where you can sit down, and you might encounter the dog walker or you might see the raised beds, or the orchard in blossom. All those simple things of life are present as well.

Transforming urban space, particularly spaces in transition, is a common thread in the work of Observatorium, though they are less frequently involved in theatre production. Designing for theatre changes their design process considerably as Dekker integrates reflections from the production side as well as creatives in the rehearsal spaces.

> But we always include programme, usage, when sculpting. We develop sites - sculpture is a device to make really good sites: intriguing parks or spoil tips or fallow fields. So here it's already a given, there is a programme, there are a lot of people, there's an organisation. That makes it different, and I feel very much that I need to listen to everyone, to get a good design.

Incorporating the needs of the community, performers, and the pragmatic concerns of a production while observing its dramaturgy has resulted in a maze that offers the audience not only an immersive experience befitting their needs and choices within it but also an idyllic space matching the ideal bond to nature that Higashida describes and aspires to shape.

> This whole area is possibly paradise for West Glasgow. The suggestion is that this whole area is this ideal garden, and that the play is not a theatre space within a good garden but the theatre transforms all of it into a place of peace and joy.



Dramaturgy description and interviews by Sanna McGregor